of Tissarakkha's violence against the Bodhi tree—is in line with the motif of a king somewhat often besotted by his queens to the point of being under their thumbs. An emotional monarch, it might be inferred—if his queens can be interpreted as having been allowed so considerable a degree of control over his life and the realm's. Such an inference would be in keeping with the sentimentality of several of the edicts.

The Lady Macbeth figure in Ashoka's life is a character in the Northern Buddhist tradition as well, the villainous queen Tishyarakshita occupying substantial space in the *Ashokavadana*, which like the *Mahavamsa* narrates her animosity towards the Bodhi tree. Truth or myth, the story seems to have been widely believed across various Buddhist traditions of the first millennium CE, from China to Lanka. The *Ashokavadana* version is far more elaborate though different in several of its details. It shows the jealousy of Tishyarakshita as stemming from her ignorance about who this 'Bodhi' really was. Apparently, because Ashoka offered his most precious jewels to Bodhi, she thought Bodhi was a woman and thus a rival. She was incensed because 'although the king pursues his pleasure with me, he sends all the best jewels to Bodhi's place.'[6] She paid money to a sorceress to destroy Bodhi. The sorceress chanted 'some mantras and tied a thread around the Bodhi tree.' The tree began to wither and Ashoka fainted when the news reached him. Upon regaining consciousness the heartbroken monarch said he would die if the Bodhi tree perished. When Tishyarakshita consoled the sorrowful Ashoka by saying that if Bodhi died she would pleasure him, he realized how ignorant she was: 'Bodhi is not a woman', said the king, 'but a tree; it is where the Blessed One attained unsurpassed enlightenment.'[7] Realizing her mistake, the queen summoned the sorceress to revive the tree and the dying tree was restored to life. The queen's vengeance and violence are leitmotifs in both accounts but the outcomes of their actions differ radically, the moral of the story in the *Mahavamsa* being